to power after a hiatus of 15 years, Adityanath was not in the reckoning for the top post. The experienced Manoj Sinha, then a Union minister of state, and Keshav Prasad Maurya, state BJP president, were the front-runners. How Adityanath was chosen remains a matter of speculation, but it is widely believed that Prime Minister Modi and then BJP president Shah, in consultation with the top brass of the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS), decided that Adityanath had the grit to handle what is arguably one of India's most difficult states to govern. To pacify the other aspirants, two of them were made deputy chief ministers and a clutch of others, ministers. The Opposition mocked the BJP government for having 10 and a half chief ministers—Adityanath being the half.

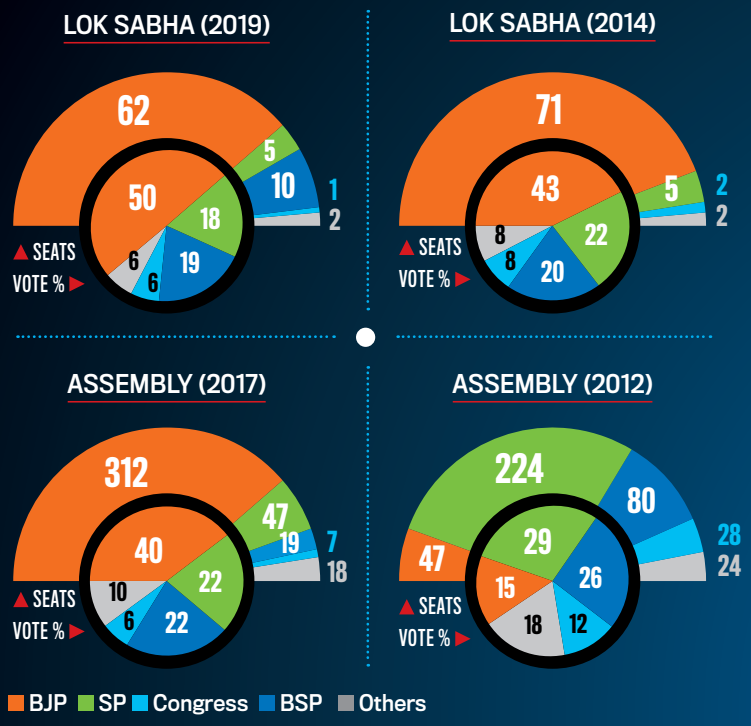
INITIALLY, ADITYANATH RODE the Hindutva chariot unabashedly, in a spell of his rule that critics termed "tyrannical". He declared war on 'love jihad' and even had an ordinance passed prohibiting religious conversion in the name of love. He also formed 'anti-Romeo squads', ostensibly for the safety of women although, all too often, they ended up intimidating genuinely courting couples. He gave the state police a free hand to gun down criminals, if need be, which soon led to charges of encounter killings. He clamped down on cow smuggling and slaughter and set up *gaushalas* (cow protection homes) across UP at a huge cost. And to the dismay of babudom, in a state where speaking with a mouthful of paan is an art as is spitting its juice out edgewise, he banned the use of tobacco and gutka and chewing paan in government offices.

A major electoral setback on his home turf Gorakhpur in his first year saw him settle down to the serious business of governing a state that would rank as the world's fifth most populous country were it an independent nation. Adityanath was advised to focus more on the welfare and development of the state for, as one aide put it, "His *bhagwa* (saffron) credentials were a given and wouldn't get him more votes." Adityanath believes he has done a good job of his tenure as CM (*see inter-*

Graphics by **TANMOY CHAKRABORTY**

THE PAST RECORD

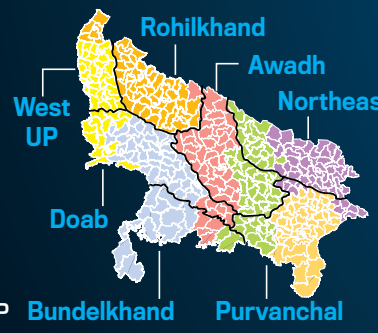
Since 2014, the BJP has won at least 40 per cent of the vote in major elections in Uttar Pradesh (to the Lok Sabha/ Vidhan Sabha), making it the dominant party



Note: The SP fought the 2017 assembly poll in alliance with the Congress; for the 2019 Lok Sabha polls, it was in alliance with the BSP

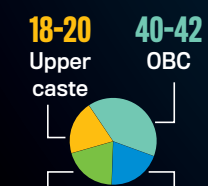
POLITICAL WAVE

The polls will be conducted over seven days between February 10 and March 7, in a wave from west to east UP



PHASE	DATE	SEATS
I	Feb. 10	58
II	Feb. 14	55
III	Feb. 20	59
IV	Feb. 23	59
V	Feb. 27	61
VI	Mar. 3	57
VII	Mar. 7	54

UP's CASTE BREAKUP (%)



UPPER CASTES
Brahmins: **9-10%**
Thakurs: **5-6%**
Kayasthas: **2%**
Vaishya/ Baniya: **2%**
Others: **2%**

OBCs
Yadavs **9%**
Non-Yadavs (Kurmis **6-7%**, Jats **4-5%**, Lodhs **3%**)

MBCs/ EBCs*
Mauryas: **4%**, Kushwaha/ Shakya, Kahar/ Kashyap: **3%**, Kewat/ Mallah/ Nishad: **3%**, Kumhar/ Prajapati: **2%**, Nonia-Chauhan: **2%**, Bind, Biyar, Rajbhar: **3%** Others: **3%**, Total MBCs/ EBCs): 20% (approx.)

DALITS
Jatavs: 11-12%
Non-Jatavs: 8-9%

Sources: Election Commission of India; India Today-MyAxis post-poll survey

**MBC/ EBC: Most backward class/ economically backward class*